

Rivers of ice

Glaciers are found on high mountain ranges all over the world, even on the equator. This is because the higher you climb, the colder it gets. If it is cold enough for snow to survive all year round, it can form a glacier. Some glaciers, called ice caps, cover huge highland areas.

Aletsch Glacier

Bernese Alps



Location Southwest Switzerland

Type Valley glacier

Length 15.3 miles (24.7 km)

Area 33.5 sq miles (86.7 sq km)

The Aletsch is one of the longest Alpine glaciers. It descends from an altitude of 13,583 ft (4,140 m) near the Jungfrau peak, is joined by two more glaciers, and extends south for almost 15.5 miles (25 km) toward the valley of the Rhône.

Khumbu Glacier

Himalayas



Location Nepal

Type Valley glacier

Length 7.5 miles (12 km)

Area 18 sq miles (45 sq km)

This Himalayan glacier has become famous as part of the southern route to Mount Everest. Climbers leaving base camp have to negotiate its steep, deeply crevassed upper section, the Khumbu Icefall, on their way to Everest's summit.

Franz Josef Glacier

New Zealand



Location Southern Alps, South Island

Type Valley glacier

Length 6.4 miles (10.3 km)

Area 12.6 sq miles (32.6 sq km)

The climate in New Zealand's Southern Alps allows the Franz Josef Glacier to descend into lush green forests near sea level. Since 2008, it has been retreating rapidly, exposing large areas of barren rock in a valley that was once packed with deep ice.



Vatnajökull

Iceland



Location Southeast Iceland

Type Ice cap

Area 3,127 sq miles (8,100 sq km)

This massive sheet of ice is the biggest glacier in Europe. It forms a frozen dome over almost a tenth of Iceland, including several volcanoes. Heat from these volcanoes melts the ice to create lakes underneath the glacier. In 1996, an eruption of Grímsvötn, the most active

volcano, caused a dramatic flood of glacial meltwater.

► DEEP FREEZE

The ice of Vatnajökull in Iceland is 1,300 ft (400 m) thick on average, and overflows into several channels called outlet glaciers.